

RAJASTHAN & GUJARAT ORIGIN

Bajra Roti

Pearl Millet Flatbread

The Desert's Warming Winter Bread

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

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Bajra Roti

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ABOUT THIS BOOK

Bajra Roti

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Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Bread Born of the Arid Lands

Long before wheat became India's dominant grain, millets like bajra (pearl millet) were the backbone of daily bread across the arid regions of Rajasthan, Gujarat, and Haryana — areas where the hardy, drought-resistant crop thrived in soil and climate too harsh for wheat. Bajra roti remains a direct link to that older agricultural tradition, still cooked daily in many rural households across these states.

In traditional Ayurvedic thinking, bajra is considered a "warming" grain, and bajra roti has long been associated specifically with winter eating — a practical pairing, since the millet's harvest season aligns with the cooler months, and its heartiness suits the season's appetite. It's often eaten with jaggery, garlic chutney, or a generous amount of ghee, simple accompaniments that let the grain's earthy, slightly nutty flavor come through.

Like makki ki roti, bajra flour contains no gluten, so the bread is traditionally patted by hand rather than rolled — a technique passed down through generations of home cooks who learned to work with, rather than against, the grain's natural texture.

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THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Bread Born of the Arid Lands, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

A daily staple in rural Rajasthan, Gujarat, and Haryana, historically more common than wheat bread in these arid regions. Associated with winter eating in Ayurvedic food tradition, believed to have a warming effect on the body. Traditionally served with garlic chutney, jaggery, or ghee rather than elaborate curries, reflecting its farmhouse origins. Naturally gluten-free, making it an increasingly popular choice among health-conscious cooks today.

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AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

15m	10m	15m	4
ACTIVE PREP	REST TIME	COOK TIME	SERVINGS (5 ROTIS)

Med
DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Mixing bowl
- Two sheets of plastic or parchment (for patting, in place of a rolling pin)
- Heavy tava or cast-iron skillet
- Tongs, for optional open-flame finishing
- Basting brush or spoon for ghee

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Like other millet-based doughs, bajra roti dough is best mixed fresh right before cooking, as it dries out and cracks if left standing too long. Cooked rotis are best eaten warm; they firm up considerably once cooled and don't reheat as softly as wheat-based breads.

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WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dough

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Bajra flour (pearl millet flour)	2 cups	250 g	2 katori
Water, warm	¾–1 cup	180–240 ml	¾–1 katori
Salt	½ tsp	3 g	to taste
Ghee, for cooking and serving	3 tbsp	45 g	3 chammach

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Bajra flour is available at South Asian and increasingly at general health food grocers, often labeled "pearl millet flour." Since it's naturally gluten-free, this recipe is a good option for gluten-free cooks, though it does require a gentler patting technique rather than rolling — see the instructions for guidance. For the freshest flavor, buy bajra flour in small quantities, as it can turn slightly bitter if stored too long.

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STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Making the Dough

01 MIX THE DOUGH

Combine the bajra flour and salt in a bowl. Gradually add warm water, mixing with your hands until a soft, cohesive dough forms — it will feel more delicate than a wheat dough, similar to makki roti.

02 REST BRIEFLY

Cover and rest for about 10 minutes to let the flour fully absorb the water, making it easier to handle.

Chef tip. keep your hands lightly wet while working with bajra dough — it prevents cracking far better than dusting with dry flour.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The dough should hold together in a soft ball without crumbling, though it will still feel more fragile than a typical wheat dough.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Patting & Cooking

03 DIVIDE AND PAT

Divide into 5 portions. Pat each gently between two sheets of plastic or parchment into a round about ¼ inch / 6 mm thick, using your palms rather than a rolling pin.



04 TRANSFER TO THE TAVA

Peel back the top sheet and use the bottom sheet to carefully flip the roti onto a medium-hot tava, handling gently since the dough is delicate.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Patting & Cooking, continued

05 COOK SLOWLY

Cook for about 2 minutes per side, pressing gently with a spatula, until both sides show golden-brown spots.



06 FINISH AND SERVE

For extra char, finish briefly over an open flame using tongs, similar to tandoori roti. Brush generously with ghee and serve immediately.

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STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

Patting & Cooking, continued

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Dusting with dry flour to prevent sticking, rather than keeping your hands damp, is a common mistake that makes bajra dough crack and crumble. Moisture is your friend with this dough, not flour.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served hot with garlic chutney and a generous amount of ghee.
- A classic winter pairing with a small piece of jaggery on the side.

Restaurant Presentation

- Served alongside a rustic thali with seasonal vegetable curries and pickle.

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SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Family Style

- Cooked fresh to order and eaten immediately, since it's at its best warm off the tava.

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RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Texture Right

- Fresh bajra flour makes a noticeable difference — older flour turns slightly bitter and is harder to bind into a smooth dough.
- Keep your palms lightly wet throughout the patting process rather than reaching for dry flour.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Mix the dough fresh each time for the best texture — it doesn't hold well overnight.
- Prepare your garlic chutney or curry accompaniment ahead of time so the roti is served hot the moment it's ready.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Rajasthani households mix a small amount of boiled potato or a spoon of yogurt into the dough for a softer, more forgiving texture — a helpful trick for beginners.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

135 kcal	3.5 g	21 g	4.5 g	3 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with fat used and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Bajra-Wheat Roti	a half-and-half blend for a softer, easier-to-roll dough.
Stuffed Bajra Roti	filled with spiced radish or fenugreek leaves, a hearty winter variation.
Bajra Methi Roti	fresh fenugreek leaves worked directly into the dough for extra flavor and nutrition.

Is bajra roti gluten-free?

Yes, entirely, as long as no wheat flour is added — a good option for those avoiding gluten.

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BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Why does my dough keep cracking?

Bajra flour has no gluten, so it needs gentle handling and consistent moisture — keep your palms wet and work quickly once the dough is mixed.

Can I make this ahead for the week?

The dough itself doesn't keep well, but you can pre-measure the dry flour and salt in advance, mixing fresh with water each time you cook.

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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



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REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Bajra	pearl millet, a hardy, drought-resistant grain traditional to arid Indian regions.
Chutney	a spiced, often garlic-based condiment traditionally served alongside this bread.
Atta	a general Hindi term for flour, though bajra atta specifically refers to pearl millet flour.
Ghee	clarified butter, essential both for cooking and serving this bread.

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PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Bajra Roti

15m ACTIVE PREP	**10m** REST TIME
15m COOK TIME	**4** SERVINGS (5 ROTIS)
Med DIFFICULTY	

DOUGH

Bajra flour	250 g
Water	180–240 ml
Salt	3 g
Ghee	45 g

METHOD

01 **Mix the dough.** Combine the bajra flour and salt in a bowl.

02 **Rest briefly.** Cover and rest for about 10 minutes to let the flour fully absorb the water, making it easier to handle.

03 **Divide and pat.** Divide into 5 portions.

04 **Transfer to the tava.** Peel back the top sheet and use the bottom sheet to carefully flip the roti onto a medium-hot tava, handling gently since the dough is delicate.

05 **Cook slowly.** Cook for about 2 minutes per side, pressing gently with a spatula, until both sides show golden-brown spots.

06 **Finish and serve.** For extra char, finish briefly over an open flame using tongs, similar to tandoori roti.

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BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

- [ ] Bajra flour — 250 g
- [ ] Ghee — 45 g
- [ ] Salt — 3 g

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